There is a difference between the genetic reality and the rigid and strictly hierarchical ‘Varna’ system of castes described in the Manusmriti (Laws of Manu). The Manusmriti is often used by scholars as the framework to understand the phenomenon of castes. It now appears that the formal ‘Varna’ based caste system described in the text is a scholarly abstraction that may never have existed in reality. [34] Instead, what we have here is a very flexible and organic milieu consisting of Jatis that can adapt easily to changing times by allowing for evolving social equations. For instance, the system can spontaneously create new castes whenever new groups need to be accommodated. Similarly, groups can be promoted or demoted in status according to prevailing social conditions. This fits what we know from historical experience—including the formation of the warrior Rajput caste in the medieval period. In the past, these groups vied with each other to move up the pecking order. Today we have the opposite situation where they vie to be classified as ‘backward’ in order to benefit from affirmative action. The logic of collective action is the same.